

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Volume I: The Covenant (Revised)

THE EXORCISM OF EMILY ROSE

BOOK I: THE COVENANT

CHAPTER 1: THE PREDATOR

The courtroom smelled of floor wax, old wood, and the specific, acrid sweat of a man who knows he is about to lose everything.

Erin Bruner stood at the defense table, her hand resting lightly on the mahogany. She didn't look at the jury. Not yet. She looked at the prosecutor, a man named Miller who was currently sweating through his cheap polyester suit. Miller was droning on about "justice" and "societal debt," words that meant nothing in this room. In this room, there was only one currency: Doubt.

And Erin was rich.

She glanced at her client, James Van Hopper. He was a small man with eyes like dead fish—flat, black, and devoid of anything resembling a soul. He was guilty. Erin knew it. Karl Gunderson, the senior partner watching from the gallery, knew it. Even the bailiff, who was currently fighting a losing battle against sleep, knew it. Van Hopper had killed his wife. He had strangled her with a telephone cord in a fit of rage because she burned the roast.

But "knowing" and "proving" were two different countries, and Erin held the passport between them.

She remembered the cross-examination of Mrs. Higgins two days ago. That had been the turning point. The old woman had sat in the witness box, clutching her purse like a shield.

"Mrs. Higgins," Erin had said, her voice soft, almost matronly. *"You stated that you saw Mr. Van Hopper's car leave the driveway at 5:45 PM. Is that correct?"*

"Yes, ma'am. I was watching 'Days of Our Lives'. It goes to commercial at 5:45."

"I see. And you watched from your living room window?"

"Yes."

Erin had walked to the defense table and picked up a photograph.

"This is a photo of your living room window, taken from the street. There is a large oak tree in the front yard. Is that correct?"

"Yes."

"And on October 14th... the leaves would still be on the tree, wouldn't they?"

Mrs. Higgins had hesitated. *"I... suppose so."*

"And it was raining that day. Heavy rain."

"It was drizzling."

"Actually," Erin produced a weather report, *"it was raining 1.2 inches an hour. A downpour. So, Mrs. Higgins... you claim you saw a car... through a rain-slicked window... through the branches of an oak tree... from fifty feet away."*

"I know what I saw."

*"Do you? Or do you know what the police *told* you that you saw?"*

Mrs. Higgins had flushed red. *"He's a bad man! I heard them fighting!"*

"Objection," Erin had said, bored. *"'Hearsay.'"

That was the moment. The moment the jury decided that maybe, just maybe, the old lady was confused. And if she was confused about the car, maybe she was confused about the screaming.

"Ms. Bruner?" Judge Holloway asked. "Your closing?"

Erin moved. She didn't walk; she glided. It was a practiced movement, designed to draw every eye in the room. She wore a tailored grey suit—Armani, bought with the bonus from the Carruthers acquittal—that was professional enough to command respect but feminine enough to disarm the older men on the jury.

"Ladies and gentlemen," Erin began. Her voice was low, forcing the jurors to lean in. It was a trick she learned in her first year. *"Make them come to you."* "Mr. Miller talks about justice. He talks about the tragedy of Mrs. Van Hopper's death. And it is a tragedy."

She paused, letting the silence stretch until it was almost uncomfortable. The air conditioning hummed, a low thrum that sounded like a mechanical heartbeat.

"But we are not here to mourn. We are here to determine facts. And the fact is, the timeline doesn't fit."

She walked to the timeline exhibit. A simple piece of foam board that was about to save a murderer.

"The State claims Mr. Van Hopper was home at 6:00 PM. But Mrs. Higgins, the neighbor... the State's own witness... testified she saw his car leaving at 5:45. Fifteen minutes." Erin turned to the jury, locking eyes with Juror Number 4, a schoolteacher who had been nodding along with Miller earlier. "Fifteen minutes. That is the difference between a murderer and a grieving husband. Can you be sure? Can you look at this man and say, with absolute certainty, that Mrs. Higgins—a woman who admitted she wasn't wearing her glasses—saw what she claims she saw?"

She saw the doubt bloom in Juror 4's eyes. It was a physical thing, a subtle shift in posture, a slight furrowing of the brow.

Got you, Erin thought.

"If you have even a shadow of a doubt," Erin whispered, "you must acquit. That is the law. That is the promise we make to every citizen. Even the ones we don't like."

She sat down.

Van Hopper leaned over. "That was good," he whispered. His breath smelled of mints and rot. A smell that stuck in the back of your throat.

"Don't talk to me," Erin said, her voice devoid of warmth. "Look at the table. Look sad."

"I *am* sad, Erin. I loved her."

Erin didn't look at him. She looked at her fingernails. Perfect. Manicured.

You loved her so much you strangled her until her eyes popped, she thought. *But the State didn't find the cord. And without the cord, they have nothing.*

The jury filed out.

The waiting began.

This was the part Erin hated. The limbo.

She sat in the hallway, drinking a lukewarm coffee from the vending machine. It tasted like burnt plastic and sugar.

Karl sat next to her.

"You got them," he said.

"Number 4 is wavering. He's a moralist."

"He's a teacher. He likes logic. You gave him logic."

"I gave him a loophole, Karl. There's a difference."

Karl laughed. He lit a cigarette, ignoring the 'No Smoking' sign. The smoke curled up, blue and grey in the fluorescent light.

"Legal truth is the only truth that matters, Erin. Did the State prove its case? No. Therefore, James Van Hopper is innocent."

"Is he?"

"In the eyes of the law? Yes. In the eyes of God? That's not our department."

Erin watched the smoke.

God, she thought. *I haven't thought about Him since I was twelve.*

She grew up Catholic. She remembered the incense. The statues. The feeling of being watched.

But law school had burned that out of her. Law school taught her that there was no divine judge. There was just a judge appointed by the Governor, who probably cheated on his taxes.

"The jury is back," the bailiff called out.

The courtroom was silent.

"We the jury," the foreman read, his voice shaking slightly.

Erin held her breath. This was the drug. The rush. The moment where life and death hung on a single word.

"...find the defendant, James Van Hopper..."

Erin looked at Van Hopper. He was squeezing his eyes shut.

"...Not Guilty."

A gasp from the gallery. Mrs. Van Hopper's sister burst into tears.

"No! He did it! You know he did it!"

The judge banged his gavel. "Order! Order in this court!"

Erin didn't smile. She didn't pump her fist. She simply nodded, a mask of professional solemnity. But inside, the adrenaline hit her like a drug. It was better than sex. It was better than love. It was the pure, uncut high of winning.

She packed her briefcase, ignoring Van Hopper's outstretched hand.

"You're a wizard, Erin," he said.

"I'm a lawyer, James," she said, snapping the locks shut. "There's a difference. Pay the bill."

She walked out of the courtroom, the heels of her shoes clicking a rhythm on the marble floor. *Click-clack. Click-clack.* The sound of a predator leaving the kill site.

Mrs. Van Hopper's sister was waiting in the hallway.

She lunged at Erin.

"How do you sleep?" she screamed, spit flying from her mouth. "How do you sleep at night knowing what you did?"

Security guards grabbed her, pulling her back.

Erin stopped. She looked at the woman.

"I sleep just fine," Erin said.

It was a lie.

But it was a good one.

She pushed through the revolving doors, out into the city.

It was raining. A cold, grey drizzle that slicked the streets.

Erin opened her umbrella. A black dome against the grey sky.

She hailed a cab.

"Where to, lady?" the driver asked.

"The Gavel," she said. "And step on it. I need a drink."

She looked out the window as the city blurred by.

She had won.

So why did she feel like she had just lost something important?

Something she couldn't even name.

CHAPTER 2: THE VICTORY LAP

The bar was called "The Gavel," because lawyers were nothing if not uncreative with their watering holes. It was dark, smoky, and loud. The air was thick with the smell of expensive scotch, cheap beer, and ambition. It was the kind of place where deals were made in the shadows and reputations were dissected over ice.

The firm had rented out the back room. It was a sea of suits. Grey, black, navy. The uniform of the soldier ant.

"To Erin!"

The toast came from everywhere. Glasses clinked.

Erin raised her vodka tonic. She took a sip. It was cold, sharp, and clean. It washed away the taste of Van Hopper's breath.

"You really pulled that one out of the fire," Ray said, sliding into the booth next to her. Ray was a junior associate who looked at Erin with a mix of terrified awe and lust. He was twenty-five, fresh out of Harvard, and still believed that the law was about Justice.

"I thought the neighbor's testimony was going to sink us," Ray continued, loosening his tie. "When she said she saw the car... I thought we were done."

"The neighbor was senile, Ray," Erin said, leaning against the padded leather of the booth. "You just had to remind the jury that she watches *Soap Operas* all afternoon. Reality blurs for people like that. They see drama where there is only rain."

Ray laughed, but it was a nervous sound. He took a long pull of his beer.

"Still. Van Hopper... he did it, right?"

Erin froze. She looked at him. The question hung in the air, heavy and wet, cutting through the noise of the party.

She turned slowly to face him. Her eyes were cold.

"Ray," she said, her voice dropping to that dangerous register she used in court when she was about to gut a witness. "Did the jury say he did it?"

"No."

"Did the judge say he did it?"

"No."

"Then he didn't do it."

"But... moral truth?" Ray stammered. "I mean, the guy had a history of domestic violence. The wife had bruises..."

"Moral truth is for priests and poets, Ray. We deal in legal truth. And legal truth is a construct. It's a building we build, brick by brick, out of evidence and procedure. If the building stands, the client walks. If it falls, they go to jail. Today, the building stood."

She turned away, dismissing him. She couldn't have this conversation. Not tonight. Not when the adrenaline was still humming in her veins.

She scanned the room.

Success.

It looked like this. Tailored suits, laughter, the promise of bonuses.

So why did she feel like she was standing at the bottom of a deep well?

She looked at her reflection in the mirror behind the bar.

Who are you?

The woman in the mirror didn't answer. She just looked tired. Her blonde hair was perfect, her makeup was flawless, but her eyes... there was a hollowness there.

The adrenaline was fading, leaving behind the crash. The emptiness.

She had saved a monster today. And she would get a raise for it.

She pushed past Ray and walked to the payphone in the hallway. It smelled of stale tobacco and old gum.

She dialed a number she knew by heart.

Ring. Ring. Ring.

"Hello?"

Her mother's voice. Tired. Small.

"Hey, Mom."

"Erin? Is everything okay? It's late."

"I know. I just... I won the case, Mom. Van Hopper. He walked."

Silence on the other end.

"That's... good, honey. I know you worked hard."

"It's huge, Mom. Karl is talking about the partnership. The Senior Partnership."

"That's wonderful, Erin. Really." A pause. "Did you go to Mass on Sunday?"

Erin closed her eyes, leaning her forehead against the cold metal of the phone box.

"No, Mom. I was working."

"You work too much. You need... you need something else in your life."

"I have a life, Mom. I have a career."

"You have a job, Erin. A life is... family. Faith."

"I have to go, Mom. The party is loud."

"Okay. I'll pray for you."

"Thanks."

Erin hung up. The dial tone hummed for a second before she slammed the receiver down.

Pray for me.

As if prayer changed anything. Prayer hadn't saved Mrs. Van Hopper. Prayer hadn't stopped James from wrapping that cord around her neck.

Only a good lawyer had saved him.

"Trouble at home?"

Erin spun around.

It was Mark Campbell. A prosecutor from the DA's office. He was leaning against the wall, holding a beer. He looked disheveled, like he had had a long day.

"Campbell," Erin said, composing herself. "Spying on the enemy?"

"Just getting a drink. Congratulations on Van Hopper. That was... masterful. Evil, but masterful."

"I'll take that as a compliment."

"You should. You made a jury believe that rain makes cars invisible. That's a special kind of magic."

"It's not magic, Mark. It's doubt."

Mark took a sip of his beer. "You know he's going to do it again, right? Guys like that... they don't stop. Next time, he won't use a cord. He'll use a knife. Or a gun."

"And next time, maybe you'll have better evidence," Erin said, brushing past him.

"How do you live with it, Erin?" Mark asked quietly.

Erin stopped. She didn't turn around.

"I win, Mark. That's how I live with it."

She walked back into the bar, but the noise was too much now. It sounded like static. Like screaming.

She found Karl Gunderson in the corner, holding court with the junior partners.

"You're not celebrating," he observed, seeing her face.

"I am. Internally."

"Save it," Karl said, his voice cutting through the noise. "I need you in my office tomorrow morning. Early."

"Good news?"

Karl smiled. It was the smile of a shark who just smelled blood in the water.

"Big news. The Archdiocese."

"Church business? I thought they had their own lawyers."

"Not for this. This is... special." Karl swirled his scotch. The amber liquid caught the light. "Go home, Erin. Get some sleep. You're going to need it."

Erin looked at him.

"Is it bad?"

"It's a homicide, Erin. A priest killed a nun. Or a student. It's messy."

"And you want me?"

"I want the woman who let James Van Hopper walk. I need a miracle worker."

Erin nodded. She finished her drink in one swallow.

"I'll see you at eight."

She walked out of the bar, into the rain.

The city was dark. The streetlights reflected in the puddles like eyes.

She hailed a cab.

She felt cold.

Not just the weather.

A deep, internal cold.

As if she had just agreed to something she didn't understand.

As if she had just signed a contract in invisible ink.

CHAPTER 3: THE HANGOVER

The dream was always the same.

Erin was standing in a courtroom. But it wasn't a normal courtroom. The walls were made of black, dripping tar. The judge's bench was a towering throne of bone.

The defendant was herself.

She was naked, shivering in the cold.

The prosecutor was James Van Hopper. But his eyes were gone. Just empty sockets weeping black oil.

"She knew," Van Hopper whispered. His voice came from everywhere at once. "She knew what I was. And she let me go."

The jury laughed. It was the sound of breaking glass.

Erin looked at the jury box.

It was filled with corpses.

Mrs. Van Hopper. The boy she had defended in the drunk driving case. The girl from the arson trial.

They were all looking at her.

"Guilty," they chanted. "Guilty. Guilty."

The floor opened up beneath her.

She fell.

Down.

Down.

Into the dark.

Erin woke up with a gasp, sitting bolt upright in bed.

Her heart was hammering against her ribs like a trapped bird. *Thump-thump-thump.*

She looked around the room.

Chrome. Glass. White sheets.

Her condo.

She was safe.

She looked at the clock.

6:00 AM.

The alarm hadn't even gone off yet.

She swung her legs out of bed. Her head throbbed—a dull, rhythmic ache behind her left eye. The vodka tonic.

She walked to the bathroom, her feet sinking into the deep pile carpet. It felt like walking on moss.

She turned on the tap. Cold water.

She splashed her face, gasping at the shock.

She looked at herself in the mirror.

Thirty-six years old. Partner track. Successful.

And terrified of her own dreams.

She started her routine. It was a ritual. A way to impose order on chaos.

Shower. Hot. Scrub the skin until it's pink. Wash away the dream.

Brush teeth. Two minutes exactly.

Floss.

Hair. Pulled back. Tight. No stray strands. Control.

Makeup. Foundation to hide the circles under her eyes. Mascara to make them look sharp. Lipstick. "Power Red."

She walked to the kitchen.

It was a masterpiece of modern design. Stainless steel appliances that cost more than her first car. Granite countertops.

And silence.

"Jasper?" she called out.

The Persian cat usually ran to her in the morning, demanding food.

Today, he was silent.

Erin frowned.

"Jasper?"

She found him in the living room.

He was standing in the center of the rug.

He wasn't moving.

He was staring at the front door.

His tail was twitching. *Swish. Swish.*

"What is it, buddy?" Erin asked, kneeling down. "You see a bug?"

Jasper didn't look at her. He hissed.

A low, guttural sound that didn't sound like a cat at all.

Erin looked at the door.

It was locked. The deadbolt was thrown. The chain was on.

But the air in the room felt... strange.

Charged.

Like the air before a thunderstorm. The hair on Erin's arms stood up.

Static electricity?

She walked to the door and checked the peephole.

Nothing. Just the empty hallway.

"You're being paranoid," she whispered to herself. "It's the hangover. It's the dream."

She went back to the kitchen and made coffee. Black. Strong.

She stood by the floor-to-ceiling window, looking out at the city.

Chicago was waking up. A grey beast stretching its limbs. Rain slicked the streets below, turning the headlights of cars into streaks of blood and gold.

She took a sip of coffee.

It tasted... metallic.

She frowned. She looked at the cup.

It was fine.

She took another sip.

Copper. It tasted like copper. Like old pennies. Or blood.

She poured the coffee into the sink.

"Filter must be bad," she muttered.

She grabbed her briefcase. She checked the locks one last time.

She looked at Jasper. He was still staring at the door.

"Bye, Jasper. Be good."

She opened the door and stepped out into the hall.

She locked it behind her.

As she walked to the elevator, she heard a sound from inside her apartment.

Thump.

A heavy, dull sound.

Like a body hitting the floor.

Erin froze.

She put her ear to the door.

Silence.

"Jasper?"

Nothing.

Maybe he jumped off the counter.

Yeah. That was it.

She pressed the elevator button.

But as the doors closed, she couldn't shake the feeling that she had left something behind.

Or that something had been waiting for her to leave.

something that was now inside, alone with the cat.

CHAPTER 4: THE SUMMIT

Karl Gunderson's office was designed to make you feel small.

It was located on the 40th floor, the "Partner's Skydeck." The ceilings were twenty feet high. The windows were vast sheets of glass that offered a view of the lake, the city, and the curvature of the earth.

Karl sat behind a desk that looked like it had been carved from the hull of a Viking ship.

He was reading a file.

He didn't look up when Erin entered.

"Sit," he said.

Erin sat in one of the leather chairs. They were low, forcing her to look up at him. A classic power move.

"You look like hell," Karl said, finally looking up.

"Bad dreams," Erin said. "And the coffee tasted like pennies."

"Copper piping. Building is getting old." Karl closed the file. "But you're here. Early. Good."

He slid the file across the desk.

"Father Richard Moore."

Erin picked it up. It was thin. Surprisingly thin for a homicide.

"Tell me," she said.

"Negligent homicide," Karl said, leaning back. "The victim was Emily Rose. Nineteen years old. Student at the university. She died two weeks ago."

"Died of what?"

"Malnutrition. Dehydration. Exhaustion. The Medical Examiner says she starved to death."

"And the priest?"

"The priest was conducting an exorcism. He convinced her she was possessed. He told her to stop taking her medication for epilepsy. He told her to fast."

Erin opened the file. She saw the photo of Emily Rose.

The "Before" photo. Smiling. Braces. Hopeful.

Then the "After" photo.

Erin's stomach turned.

The girl in the photo looked like a concentration camp victim. Her eyes were sunken black pits. Her skin was bruised, lacerated. Her mouth was a rictus of terror.

"My god," Erin whispered.

"The DA is Ethan Thomas," Karl said.

Erin looked up sharply. "Thomas? The crusader?"

"The very one. He's treating this as a holy war. He wants to prove that religious superstition killed this girl. He wants to put the Church on trial."

"And the Church wants me to stop him."

"The Church wants you to get an acquittal. Or at least a mistrial. They don't care about the theology, Erin. They care about the liability. If Moore is convicted, the family sues the Archdiocese. We're talking millions in damages. The PR fallout alone would be catastrophic."

"So I'm a janitor," Erin said. "Cleaning up a mess."

"You're a defense attorney," Karl corrected. "It's the same thing, just with better suits."

Erin looked at the photo of Emily again.

"Did he do it?" she asked.

"Did he kill her?" Karl shrugged. "Legally? Maybe. The negligence statute is broad. If he had a duty of care and he breached it... yes. But morally? He thinks he was saving her soul."

"Moral truth again," Erin said, a bitter taste in her mouth.

"It's going to be the central theme of the trial, Erin. Science vs. Faith. Medicine vs. Religion. Thomas is going to bring in doctors, psychiatrists, experts who will say Emily was epileptic and psychotic. He will say Moore was a dangerous fanatic."

"And what do I say?"

"You say that Emily Rose believed she was possessed. And that she had the right to choose her treatment. Even if that treatment was prayer."

"That's a weak defense, Karl. 'She wanted to die' doesn't play well with a jury."

"It's not 'she wanted to die'. It's 'she wanted to be saved'. There's a difference."

Karl leaned forward. His eyes were hard.

"This is the big one, Erin. The partners are watching. If you win this... the Senior Partnership is yours. Your name on the door. The corner office. The view."

He gestured to the window. The city lay spread out below them, grey and rain-swept.

"Everything you've worked for."

Erin looked at the view. It was beautiful. And cold.

"And if I lose?"

"Then you're the lawyer who let a priest go to jail for killing a teenage girl. You'll be toxic. You'll be doing traffic court in Skokie."

The threat was clear.

Erin closed the file.

"I'll take it."

"Good." Karl smiled. "He's at the County Jail. Go see him. But be careful, Erin."

"Careful of what? The press?"

"The priest," Karl said. "He's... intense. And from what I hear, he's not alone in that cell."

"What does that mean?"

Karl hesitated. For the first time, the shark looked unsure.

"It means," he said quietly, "that people who get close to this case... they tend to start seeing things. Hearing things."

"You're joking."

"Just watch your back, Erin. And don't let him get inside your head."

Erin stood up. She grabbed the file.

"I don't believe in ghosts, Karl. I believe in reasonable doubt."

"Let's hope the jury agrees," Karl said.

Erin walked out of the office.

The hallway seemed longer than usual.

The lights flickered overhead.

Bzzzt.

She paused.

She looked back at Karl's door.

It was closed.

She shook her head.

"Coffee," she muttered. "I need more coffee."

But as she walked to the elevator, the metallic taste in her mouth returned.

Stronger this time.

Like she was chewing on a penny.

CHAPTER 5: THE DESCENT

The drive to the County Jail was a descent in every sense of the word. Erin drove her Mercedes from the gleaming canyons of the financial district down to the rusted, graffiti-stained arteries of the south side. The architecture changed from glass and steel to brick and barbed wire. The people changed from suits to jumpsuits.

The rain had picked up. It wasn't cleansing; it was oppressive. It smeared the windshield with grey sludge. The wipers fought a losing battle. *Thwump-hiss. Thwump-hiss.*

She parked in the visitors' lot, a cracked asphalt slab surrounded by a chain-link fence topped with razor wire.

She checked her reflection in the rearview mirror. Perfect. Impenetrable.

But her hands were shaking.

Just a little.

It's the coffee, she told herself. *Too much caffeine.*

But she knew it wasn't the coffee.

It was the file. The photo of Emily Rose. The look in those black eyes.

She got out of the car, locking it with the remote. *Chirp.*

She walked to the intake center.

The smell hit her first.

It wasn't just a smell; it was a physical presence. A wall of odor.

Industrial pine cleaner trying to mask the scent of unwashed bodies. Stale cigarette smoke. Urine. And underneath it all, the metallic tang of fear. It was the smell of caged animals.

Erin breathed through her mouth.

She checked her bag with the guard, a woman named Officer Higgins (no relation to the witness, Erin hoped). Higgins had tired eyes and a belt weighed down by keys, a radio, and pepper spray.

"Attorney visit for Moore," Erin said, sliding her bar card across the scratched plexiglass.

Higgins looked at the card, then at Erin.

"You're the one," she said. It wasn't a question.

"I'm his attorney."

"Good luck," Higgins said. She slid a visitor badge back. "Block D. Solitary."

Solitary?

Erin frowned. "Why is he in solitary?"

"Warden's orders. He was... upsetting the other inmates."

"Upsetting them how?"

Higgins leaned forward. "Preaching. Screaming in Latin at night. The guys in D Block are tough, lady. Killers. Rapists. But Moore? He scares them."

Erin clipped the badge to her lapel. "I'll keep that in mind."

She walked through the metal detector. *Beep.*

"Underwire," she muttered, raising her arms.

Higgins waved the wand. "Go ahead."

The corridors were long, echoey tunnels of concrete painted a color that could only be described as "institutional despair green."

Clack. Clack. Clack.

Erin's heels sounded like gunshots in the silence.

Inmates watched her from the communal cells in B Block. Hands gripping the bars. Eyes tracking her.

"Hey, sweetness! You looking for a client?"

"I didn't do it, baby! Come talk to me!"

"Look at the legs on that one. Walking tall."

Erin didn't flinch. She stared straight ahead, her face a mask of indifference. She had walked these halls a hundred times. They were just noise. Background radiation.

But as she approached D Block, the noise stopped.

The air grew colder here.

The lights buzzed with a frantic energy.

She passed a cell. A man was standing at the bars. He was naked from the waist up, his body covered in tattoos of spiders.

He looked at Erin.

He didn't catcall. He didn't smile.

He hissed.

"We see you," he whispered.

Erin stopped. She looked at him.

"Excuse me?"

The man smiled. His teeth were filed into points.

"The one who walks with the Law. The one who sells doubt."

Erin felt a chill run down her spine.

"Do I know you?"

"We know you. We know the penny taste in your mouth. We know the cat who stares at nothing."

Erin stepped back. Her heart slammed against her ribs.

How could he know?

"Guard!" she yelled.

The guard at the end of the hall looked up from his magazine.

"Move along, counselor. Don't talk to the animals."

Erin looked back at the man.

He was gone. Retreated into the shadows of his cell.

But she could hear him laughing. A dry, scratching sound.

She walked faster.

She reached the heavy steel door of the interview room.

"He's in Interview Room 2," the guard said, unlocking it. "Watch yourself. He's been weird all night."

"Define weird."

"Talking to himself. Argumentative. Like there's two people in there."

"Is there?"

"No. Just him. And his Bible."

Erin took a deep breath. She smoothed her skirt.

She was Erin Bruner. She was a partner. She was a shark.

She wasn't afraid of a priest.

She opened the door and stepped inside.

The room was small. Claustrophobic.

Father Richard Moore sat at the metal table.

He was wearing his clerical collar, but it was dingy, frayed at the edges. His black shirt was wrinkled.

He looked up.

Erin stopped.

She expected a fanatic. A crazy person.

She saw a man who looked like he had been hollowed out by grief.

His eyes were dark, intelligent, and haunted.

"Father Moore," she said.

He didn't blink.

"You're the lawyer," he said. His voice was rough. Gravel.

"I'm Erin Bruner."

"You smell like rain," he said. "And fear."

Erin placed her briefcase on the table. *Click.*

"I'm not afraid, Father. I'm here to help you."

Moore smiled. It was a sad, terrible smile.

"No one can help me," he whispered. "The war has already begun."

Erin sat down.

"Then let's prepare for battle," she said.

But looking at him, she couldn't shake the image of the man in the cell.

We know the cat who stares at nothing.

She opened her file.

Her hand was steady.

But inside, she was screaming.